



Wipeout Pure

The PSP version of the hugely popular *Wipeout* series, *Wipeout Pure* is all about racing your hover-ship on a narrow, futuristic racetrack without blowing up. It's a lot tougher than it sounds—you will invariably find yourself bonking your ship coming out of a corner, and to make matters worse, your racing opponents are constantly firing weird and wonderful weapons at you (and vice versa).

The description doesn't sound like much, but the execution of the concept is where this game stands out. Firstly, for a game that will be played on the PSP's small screen, the game looks beautiful—no doubt the best looking of the four reviewed here. Track design is brilliant and delivers the very futuristic feel it's meant to. The hover-ships are based on two basic designs, but look good nonetheless. Controlling your craft is quite difficult initially, till you realise that the key is to use the analogue stick in conjunction with the L and R buttons.

There's also a Zone mode in the game, which puts you alone on a track, progressively increasing your speed—the goal is to last as long as possible without becoming one with the wall. Surviving long will unlock new tracks for the zone. Surprisingly, I found that the Zone mode was more exciting than the single race—especially beyond zone 20.

Wipeout Pure is a really good title to own, though nothing groundbreaking in terms of its adrenaline-pumping value. It is, no doubt, a gorgeous looking title and sounds really good even on the PSP's speakers—so you know it's going to sound excellent on a respectable pair of headphones too. The review copy we got kept crashing the PSP, but we're being optimistic and hoping that commercial copies aren't that nasty. ■



If there's any game genre that gaming console controllers are beautifully suited for, it's sports! Playing *World Tour Soccer* on the PSP is a treat; this from someone who couldn't really care less about sports games. *World Tour Soccer* offers you the option to play quick matches, exhibition matches, cup competitions and multiplayer matches. There's also the challenge mode—seven matches for you to beat and showcase some smart moves and stunts—classy steals will be rewarded, and sloppy passing will earn you negative scores. Honestly, if there were more challenge matches, the game could have stood on their shoulders alone—coupled with the amazing soundtrack, it's no doubt the most appealing part of the game.

Controlling your players is straightforward and intuitive for the most part. Special moves and sprints are easily executed and don't really require you to read the help—the controls are exactly what they should be. Friendly AI is not as smart as you would hope for, but with you on their side they seem to survive well enough.

There are plenty of unlockables here, and as you progress through the game, you will unlock new stadiums, clubs and challenges. If you're the kind that loves unlocking bonuses, this should be heaven for you. ■

